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Unit 12: Organizational Culture

UNIT FOCUS :

- **Reading :** Organizational Culture.
- **Vocabulary:** Definitions, Pairs.
- **Grammar:** Perfect Tenses: Expressing Time Relationships

"**Culture eats strategy for breakfast**."
(Peter Drucker)

Reading

Read the Text. Underline the New Words.

Every organization has a **culture [1]** that sets the **rules for behavior [2]** in that organization. Culture is the important **concerns [3]**, goals, and **values [4]** that are **shared [5]** by most people in the organization and that are likely to **persist [6]** over time. In addition, at another **level of abstraction [7]**, the culture is the style or **behavior patterns [8]** that organizational members use to guide their actions. For example, an organization whose culture values the **initiative [10]** of all its members will have a different **climate [9]** than an organization in which decisions are made by **senior managers [11]** and **enforced [12]** their subordinates. Most likely, the people in the first organization will feel more positive about the effects of their actions on organizational success and will have a greater **sense of ownership [13]** than those in the latter organization, who may feel that they have no **stake [14]** in the **organizational outcomes [15]**. The combination of **design factors [16]** drives behavior, which both shapes and reflects the values and patterns of the culture; however, the culture itself often determines the arrangement of design factors. For example, when an organization values attention to **customer service [17]** issues, measures that emphasize (internal and external) customer service may be in place. These measures in turn drive further attention to serving the customer.

Some companies can be characterized as very friendly or as highly competitive; these behaviors are quickly learned by new organizational members.

No one organization has the same culture as any other. In fact, cultures across one organization differ in some ways from unit to unit, although the **core values [18]** and **assumptions [19]** may be similar. Cultures vary on their **content [20]** (the set of basic assumptions held by the organization) and on their **strength [21]** (the **intensity [22]** of the behavior that exhibits the culture).

Content of a culture is affected by the **business environment [23]** and **industry [24]** itself. For example, an organization is an industry characterized by **rapid technological change [25]** may hold the value of **cooperation [26]** and **readiness to change [27]** as part of their culture's content. Content is also shaped by the **formal structures [28]**, plans, and policies of the organization. An organization that states it "values all its employees and encourages their learning" may have extensive **development programs [29]** that validate those assumptions. In addition, the culture is affected by the **visions [30]** of the organization's leaders and the stated strategies they have implemented to achieve those visions.

A culture's strength is influenced by the number of shared assumptions people in the organization have, the extent to which those assumptions are shared, and the priority of those assumptions. Few elements of a culture are completely shared, but each organization usually has several that are seen as crucially important to the organization.

(Allan R. Cohen, *The Portable MBA in Management*)

Glossary

1	**Culture**	The set of rules, concerns, goals, and values shared by people in an organization.
2	**Rules for Behavior**	Guidelines set by the culture that dictate how members should act.
3	**Concerns**	Important issues or topics that are prioritized by the organization's culture.
4	**Values**	Core beliefs shared by most people in the organization that drive behavior.
5	**Shared**	The state of being held in common by the majority of the organization's members.
6	**Persist**	To continue or endure over time (referring to the longevity of culture).
7	**Level of Abstraction**	A different perspective or way of viewing culture, such as seeing it as style or patterns.
8	**Behavior Patterns**	Recurring ways of acting that members use to guide their actions.
9	**Climate**	The atmosphere or feeling within an organization resulting from its culture.
10	**Initiative**	The ability of members to assess and take action independently (valued in some cultures).
11	**Senior Managers**	Top-level executives who make decisions in centralized/competitive cultures.
12	**Enforced**	Compelled or imposed, such as decisions made by managers upon subordinates.

13	**Sense of Ownership**	The feeling that employees have a personal stake in the organization's success.
14	**Stake**	An interest or involvement in the outcomes of the organization.
15	**Organizational Outcomes**	The results or consequences of the organization's actions and strategies.
16	**Design Factors**	Structural elements of an organization that drive behavior and shape culture.
17	**Customer Service**	A focus on serving clients (internal and external) which can be emphasized by culture.
18	**Core Values**	The fundamental beliefs that may be similar across different units of an organization.
19	**Assumptions**	Basic beliefs held by the organization that form the content of its culture.
20	**Content**	The specific set of basic assumptions held by the organization.
21	**Strength**	The intensity of the behavior that exhibits the culture.
22	**Intensity**	The degree of force or strength behind the behaviors exhibiting culture.
23	**Business Environment**	The external setting that affects the content of a culture.
24	**Industry**	The specific sector of business which characterizes the organization (e.g., technology).
25	**Rapid Technological Change**	A fast-paced shift in technology that characterizes certain industries.
26	**Cooperation**	Working together towards a common end; a value often held in dynamic industries.
27	**Readiness to Change**	The willingness to adapt, often part of a culture's content in tech industries.
28	**Formal Structures**	The official hierarchy and arrangement of the organization that shapes content.
29	**Development Programs**	Training initiatives used to validate and encourage specific cultural values.
30	**Visions**	The future aspirations of leaders that affect the organization's culture.

Digest what you read

A. Based on the information given in the text, select True, False, or Not Given.

.....1- Organizational culture is defined solely by the company's profits.
.....2- A culture that values employee initiative often leads to a greater sense of ownership.
.....3- The culture of an organization is completely static and never changes.
.....4- The content of a culture can be shaped by the visions of its leaders.
.....5- All assumptions in a strong culture are shared by every single employee.

B. Select the best answer for the items below. Refer to the text to check your answers.

1. **What is organizational culture**?
   A. Only the company's financial plan.

B. The shared values and behavior patterns that guide actions.
C. The physical layout of the office.
D. A list of employee names.

2. **According to the text, how does culture relate to behavior**?
   A. Behavior has no connection to culture.
   B. Culture shapes behavior, and behavior reflects culture.
   C. Behavior is only determined by managers.
   D. Culture is only about customer service.

3. **What influences the *content* of an organizational culture?**
   A. The color of the walls.
   B. The business environment and leaders' visions.
   C. The weather.
   D. The number of employees.

4. **What does a "sense of ownership" likely mean for an employee?**
   A. They own part of the company.
   B. They feel responsible and connected to the company's success.
   C. They are allowed to set their own working hours.
   D. They do not have to follow the rules.

5. **How do new organizational members learn the culture?**
   A. They take a written exam.
   B. They quickly learn the behaviors from others.
   C. They are not expected to learn it.
   D. They learn it only from the CEO.

Vocabulary Loading

A. Using the words given in Box 1, find definitions from Box 2.

Box 1	Box 2
1. Culture	A) The beliefs about what is important and worthwhile in an organization.
2. Values	B) The ideas and future goals that leaders have for the organization.
3. Initiative	C) The shared beliefs, values, and practices that guide behavior in an organization.
4. Visions	D) The ability to assess and initiate things independently.
5. Assumptions	E) Things that are accepted as true or as certain to happen, without proof.
6. Stake	E) A strong interest or involvement in something, so that you want it to succeed.

B. Find matching pairs. Translate them into Arabic.

Part 1	Part 2	Pairs	Translation
Sets	for behavior	Sets the rules for behavior	يضع قواعد السلوك
Sense of	assumptions		

Core	ownership
Basic	the rules
Readiness	values
Business	to change
Shared	environment
Affected	by
Behavior	patterns

C. Fill in the blanks using the proper words from the previous section.

1. A strong organizational _____ can improve employee satisfaction and productivity.
2. The company's _____ include integrity, innovation, and teamwork.
3. Employees who show _____ are often promoted to leadership positions.
4. The CEO's _____ is to make the company a global leader in sustainability.
5. The culture's content is _____ by the industry it operates in.

D. Enhancing Your Vocabulary

Match the words on the left with their synonyms on the right.

1. Persist | a) Crucial
2. Enforce | b) Continue
3. Determine | c) Influence
4. Affect | d) Decide
5. Crucially | e) Implement

Grammar Injection

Fill in the blanks with the correct form of the verbs from the reading.

Set, Share, Persist, Enforce, Shape, Reflect, Determine, Emphasize, Learn, Affect

1. Every organization has a culture that _____ the rules for behavior.
2. The core values are _____ by most people in the organization.
3. These values are likely to _____ over time.
4. In some companies, decisions are made by senior managers and _____ on subordinates.
5. Employee behavior both _____ and is _____ by the culture.
6. The culture itself often _____ the arrangement of design factors.

7. Some companies _____ customer service in their policies.
8. New organizational members quickly _____ the company's culture.
9. The content of a culture is _____ by the business environment.

Grammar Handling

Perfect Tenses: Expressing Time Relationships

The perfect tenses are used to show a connection in time between two events or actions. They are formed using the auxiliary verb 'to have' and the past participle of the main verb.

1. Present Perfect

- Form: has/have + past participle (e.g., has coordinated, have finished)
- Use:
    - To describe an action that happened at an unspecified time in the past.
    - To describe an action that started in the past and continues to the present.
- Signal Words: ever, never, already, yet, just, for, since, so far.
- Examples:
    - The management has implemented a new policy. (We don't know when, the result is important now.)
    - She has worked here for five years. (She started in the past and still works here now.)

2. Past Perfect

- Form: had + past participle (e.g., had coordinated, had finished)
- Use: To describe an action that was completed before another action or time in the past.
- **Examples:**
    - The team had already finished the report when the manager asked for it.
    - By the time the CEO arrived, the meeting had started.

3. Future Perfect

- Form: will have + past participle (e.g., will have coordinated, will have finished)
- Use: To describe an action that will be completed before a specific point in the future.
- **Examples:**
    - By next quarter, we will have launched the new product.
    - She will have managed the department for a decade by the time she retires.

Practice:

Complete the following sentences using the correct form of the verb in brackets (Present Perfect, Past Perfect, or Future Perfect).

1. The company _____ (achieve) all its strategic goals for this year.
2. Before he was promoted, he _____ (work) as a supervisor for three years.
3. By 2026, the economy _____ (recover) fully from the recession.
4. I _____ (not receive) the feedback from my manager yet.
5. The analyst _____ (already standardize) the process when the new manager decided to change it.
6. They _____ (invest) heavily in new technology over the last five years.

Translate the text into Arabic.

Every organization has a culture that sets the rules for behavior in that organization. Culture is the important concerns, goals, and values that are shared by most people in the organization and that are likely to persist over time. In addition, at another level of abstraction, the culture is the style or behavior patterns that organizational members use to guide their actions.
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.....

Self-check: Check your progress in this unit. Tick (√) the statements which are true about you.

• I can define organizational culture and its components.
• I understand the difference between culture's content and strength.
• I have learned more than 20 new words from this unit.
• I can identify and use the passive voice in sentences.
• This unit helped me understand my technical subject better.